The Mandayam brothers lost everything, and all their lands had to be mortgaged,[63] though the exact quantum of the investment and consequent financial loss is unclear. Following the liquidation, the eldest of the brothers, S. Thirumalachari, went into deep depression.[64] '[S. Parthasarathy], along with his brothers, gave a large portion of his family wealth for the establishment … of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company, Tuticorin', claimed a later biographical sketch with justified pride.[65] 'I incurred a terribly heavier loss in the failure of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company of V.O. Chidambaram Pillai of Tuticorin. It swept away almost all my property,' wrote S. Srinivasachari; he attributed his financial ruin to his investment 'in two great national undertakings'—Bharati's *India* and SSNCo.[66] In an intercepted letter to M.N. Roy (a revolutionary and founding member of the Communist Party of India) in 1922, M. Singaravelu Chettiar (pioneer of Buddhist revivalism and early communist) noted that S. Thirumalachari had lost 'nearly three lakhs of rupees' in SSNCo,[67] a fact confirmed by a contemporary CID report as well.[68]

More than ten years after the liquidation, wounds were still raw in those who had given their all to the company. When S.D. Krishna Aiyangar was asked by the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee (1924) if he 'did not feel any responsibility' for the liquidation of the company, the lawyer in him replied, 'It was a limited company, and I have no personal responsibility.' The evasiveness of the reply hardly masks his emotions. When probed further by the committee about 'moral responsibility', Krishna Aiyangar said, 'My conscience tells me that I was not responsible for a pie.'[69] Plain though the statement is, it is not difficult to discern his searing honesty compounded by pain.

VOC's Continuing Ordeals

How did the liquidation affect VOC? SSNCo's formal closure did not mean the end of VOC's troubles. Already suffering in prison, VOC was in for a